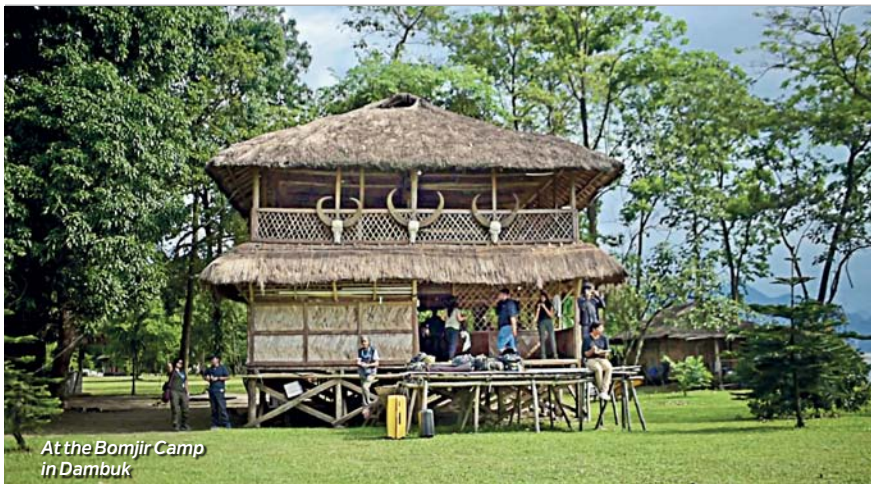

At the Bomjir Camp in Dambuk

Kambu to Mechuka, in the east, is one of the rougher bits. Mechuka was once so cut off that getting there meant a helicopter ride or a week's walk. Any road—even a bad one—is a win. We climb mist-laced mountains bursting with bloom, breeze and birdsong and arrive in Mechuka for lunch, at dinnertime. Everyone has waited five hours in the rain. But instead of being irked, they welcome us with chhang, dance, and a hot dinner.

MECHUKA'S MEADOWS

Morning shows us a spotless town at 6,000 ft on the banks of the Yargyap Chu river (the Siyom), cradled in a bowl of hills. The name 'Mechuka', or 'Menchuka', means something like 'medicinal' melt-water. We are a few dozen kilometres from the Indo-Chinese border again, and there's no phone connectivity (though BSNL has a bar or two)—and that's okay, because your phone is best used to take photos.

Wild horses graze in Mechuka's meadows, the wind gusts around prayer flags; low, swollen clouds currently hide the snowcaps. Our generous homestay host, Gebu, from the Memba tribe, is driving us around, and time is short. I must choose between the 400-year-old Samten Yongcha monastery, important enough for the Dalai Lama to visit, or the region's longest zip-line. It's a no-brainer: I've never zip-lined. It's 800-m long, right across the river, with a bird's eye view of the valley. Wheeee!

Mechuka is a strategic area. We are invited to dinner with the 13 Grenadiers. The army doesn't flinch from courtesy and ceremony, even if rain is bucketing into the rum. We meet men and women who serve far from home with fortitude and smiles; I chat with an officer from Jharkhand who has a degree in Spanish. Somehow, this incongruity feels right.

There's a lot to see and do around Mechuka, including religious things—monasteries, a gurdwara built near a cave where Guru Nanak (or Guru Rimpoche Padmasambhava, depending on who you ask) apparently meditated, and a natural rock face that looks like Hanuman if you squint. Many houses fly the flag of the widespread Donyi Polo religion (literally 'Sun Moon'). The burgeoning Rashtriya



The 2,400-km route for the Trans-Arunachal Drive covers 16 districts